

The Claremont City Council held a meeting on Wednesday, March 14, 2018, in the Council Chambers of City Hall.

The meeting was called to order by Assistant Mayor Damren at 6:30 p.m.

Members of the Council present were:

Ward I Councilor Andrew O’Hearne
Ward III Councilor Jonathan Stone
Assistant Mayor Allen Damren
At-Large Councilor Abigail Kier
At-Large Councilor Nicholas Koloski
Ward II Councilor Scott Pope

Absent:

At-Large Councilor Claire Lessard
Mayor Charlene Lovett
At-Large Councilor Jeremy Zullo

Also present:

Ryan McNutt, City Manager

AGENDA CHANGES

Mr. Damren said the plan is to skip Resolution 2018-22 as it is not ready.

REPORT OF THE SECRETARY

A motion was made by Mr. O’Hearne and seconded by Mr. Stone to accept the minutes of the February 14, 2018, City Council meeting.

Voice vote: motion carried 5-0 with 1 abstain (Mr. Pope).

A motion was made by Mr. O’Hearne and seconded by Mr. Stone to accept the minutes of the February 28, 2018, City Council meeting.

Voice vote: motion carried 4-0 with 2 abstentions (Mr. Pope and Ms. Kier).

MAYOR'S NOTES

Mr. Damren –

- Congratulated the Stevens High School (SHS) and Claremont Middle School (CMS) cheerleaders; both groups placed second in state competitions
- Recognized two SHS football players (Aiden Cahill and Nick Stone) who were named to the NH Shrine Football Team
- Valley Regional Hospital will celebrate 125 years on March 21
- Congratulations to the new School Board members: Rebecca Zullo, Jason Benware, Steven Horsky and Carolyn Towle

Mr. Damren read Mayor Lovett's notes –

- March is National Women's History Month and this year's theme is "Nevertheless She Persisted." Go to NWHP.org for more information.
- Stakeholders committed to peer recovery support services met with Executive Councilor Kenney and DHHS Commissioner Meyers
- Thank you to all who voted (14% voted)
- NH Freight Summit will be March 22, 1 p.m., Claremont Savings Bank
- Congratulations to former Councilor Carolyn Towle who will be honored April 11 with the Good Scout Award from the Daniel Webster Scouts

Mr. McNutt said the sandwich board Council had requested to remind people to vote was put out on Tuesday reminding people to vote. He said the Police and Fire Departments are working to get electronic sign boards through a grant. If we are fortunate to receive them, they can carry a message to remind people to vote.

CITY MANAGER'S REPORT

The City Manager's report was in the Council packet, but was not discussed at the meeting.

Assessor

Marlene Jordan, Assessor, will resign effective March 29 to take a position with the Lebanon Assessing Department. A person from MRI (Municipal Resources Inc.) will fill in as a temporary Assessor. We have begun advertising for a new assessor.

Opportunity Zone Program

Opportunity Zones are a new community development program established by Congress in the Tax Cuts and Jobs Act of 2017 to encourage long-term investments in low-income urban and rural communities nationwide. The Opportunity Zones program provides a tax incentive for investors to re-invest their unrealized capital gains into designated Opportunity Zones.

In April, the Governor will submit NH's (27) eligible zone recommendations to the US Treasury Dept. I am highly confident Claremont will receive a designation as an Opportunity Zone.

Winter DPW

We have had approximately (28) storms or winter events: (10) events were in December, (8) events were in January, (8) events were in February, and we have had (2) events thus far in March. With this last storm, we are at approximately 105% of winter budget at this time, which is within a normal standard deviation from the mean for the variables in winter operations.

Events are storms with plowing and snow removal operations – Large Storms, Smaller squall events that require spots treatments, lite dustings or sleet/rain events that require treatment of the roads. Materials, maintenance, and overtime are the main components of event costs.

DPW Water/Wastewater

We are coming up on the contract for the operations of the water and wastewater enterprises. In February 2017 we negotiated a one-year extension with Utility Partners, which saw a 2% reduction in the contract price. Proposals are due March 23. Utility Partners was the only firm to attend the pre-bid meeting.

Tax Deeded Properties

We have scheduled the tax auction for Saturday, June 2, 2018, 11:00 am at the Community Center. Auction is being conducted by Rick Sager NH Tax Deed & Property Auctions.

Tax Deeding - 5 Stathers Rd.
119 Main St.
111 Main St.
Providence Ave. – vacant land
7-9 Prospect St.
20 Goulet Ave. – land only/house demolished
30 W. Pleasant St. – land only/house demolished
235 Hanover St. – land only/house demolished

City of Claremont Nominated for a Municipal Energy Champion Award

New Hampshire Energy Week is March 12-16, 2018. City of Claremont to be awarded the 2018 Energy Week Municipal Energy Champion Award on March 15 in Concord. Award to be presented by former NH Senator Kelly Ayotte.

Nancy Merrill, Planning and Development Director, and Michael McCrory, City Planner, will be attending the breakfast conference.

APPOINTMENT TO BOARDS AND COMMITTEES

Claremont Community Television, Inc. (CCTV) Board of Directors

Councilors questioned the process of having to fill out a Board and Commission Application in order to fill a Council seat on the various boards.

Mr. Pope said the past practice has been that appointments were made at a Council meeting and then Councilors filled out a Board & Commission Application. He said former City Attorney Jane Taylor wanted to have the application on file.

Mr. Damren said the procedure will be discussed at a future Council meeting.

A motion was made by Ms. Kier and seconded by Mr. Stone to appoint Allen Damren to seat 1 (City Council Representative) of the Claremont Community Television, Inc. (CCTV) Board of Directors.

Voice vote: motion carried 5-0 with 1 abstain (Mr. Damren).

Claremont Development Authority

At its February 22, 2018, meeting, the Claremont Development Authority nominated the following individual for appointment to the Claremont Development Authority:

Derek Ferland

Mr. McNutt further nominated him to the City Council for appointment to the Claremont Development Authority.

A motion was made by Mr. Koloski and seconded by Mr. Stone to appoint Derek Ferland to seat 8 (Key Properties) of the Claremont Development Authority.

Voice vote: motion carried 6-0.

Claremont Planning Board

A motion was made by Ms. Kier and seconded by Mr. Pope to appoint Allen Damren to seat 9 (City Councilor) of the Claremont Planning Board.

Mr. O'Hearne said his vote will reflect that he is not happy with the process.

Voice vote: motion carried 4-1 with Mr. O'Hearne voting no; and 1 abstain (Mr. Damren).

A motion was made by Mr. Pope and seconded by Mr. Stone to appoint Nicholas Koloski to seat A-5 (City Council Alternate) of the Claremont Planning Board.

Voice vote: motion carried 4-1 with Mr. O’Hearne voting no; and 1 abstain (Mr. Koloski).

Historic District Commission

A motion was made by Ms. Kier and seconded by Mr. Stone to appoint Scott Pope to seat 2 (City Council Representative) of the Historic District Commission.

Voice vote: motion carried 4-1 with Mr. O’Hearne voting no; 1 abstain (Mr. Pope).

Zoning Board of Adjustment

A motion was made by Mr. Pope and seconded by Mr. O’Hearne to re-appoint Richard Collins to seat 1 of the Zoning Board of Adjustment.

Voice vote: motion carried 6-0.

CITIZEN’S FORUM

None

OLD BUSINESS

Resolution 2018-22 Capital Reserve from Sale of City-Owned Property – Public Hearing

Mr. Damren said the Finance Committee has asked that the resolution be more specific about what the fund could be used for. The next Finance Committee meeting will be March 20th. The Finance Committee will bring a final resolution to the Council on March 28.

NEW BUSINESS

On-Call Firefighters Information

At 6:53 p.m. Mr. Koloski asked to be excused as he is an on-call firefighter and he left the Council table.

Fire Chief Bryan Burr gave a brief overview of the Fire Department. He said the maximum number of call firefighters is 12 and they currently have 11. That number has been consistent for 10-15 years. There are two companies. Each company has a captain, lieutenant and four firefighters. There are no requirements or mandatory training through the RSAs or state fire training. The City requires they have protective clothing and self-contained breathing apparatus. They train and attend monthly meetings. Currently, there are seven scheduled trainings. They

respond to brush fires, building fires, manmade and natural disasters (i.e. hurricanes and floods). They are part of the mutual aid agreement and they can be sent to outlying communities. In 2016, call forces responded to 24 emergencies. In 2017, they responded to 13 emergencies. Since January 2018, when he became Chief, they have responded to seven incidents. Attendance is about 30-35%; there are many reasons for the low turnout (i.e. time of day, out of area, work constraints, social events and family obligations). The difference in training between the career force and the call force is based on state statutes. Career firefighters are required to become Firefighter II within the first year. There are no such requirements for call or volunteer forces. All call equipment passes NFPA (National Fire Protection Association) standards which is the same as the career force.

Mr. O'Hearne asked about equipment call firefighters use for notification. Chief Burr said they use pagers. They are four to five years old and work well. The Fire Department belongs to the Upper Valley Mutual Aid Association and they use an app called Active 9-1-1 on their cell phones that gives them pertinent information over the phone (supports the pager).

Chief Burr said the requirement for firefighters to become an EMT (Emergency Medical Technician) is a local requirement and it has to be done within a year of hiring.

There was a discussion about call firefighter responses. Chief Burr said the majority are not employed locally, however, they are required to live within 15 minutes of the Fire Station.

Nick Koloski spoke as a Ward 3 citizen. He said there are several call members who train on their own time and have attained Firefighter I and Firefighter II levels. He said it is important to have call members to supplement the career firefighters. Other departments (i.e. Springfield, Vermont) compensate their call members for training. He just reached level II, but does not plan to be a career firefighter.

Chief Burr said currently there is one call firefighter certified as a Firefighter I, five are certified as Firefighter II. Also, three are nationally registered EMTs. Some may be members of other fire departments.

Chief Burr said all call firefighters have the same opportunity as career firefighters for training and the department will pay for the training.

At 7:13 p.m. Mr. Koloski returned to the Council table.

Motion to Continue Finance Ad Hoc Committee

At its March 22, 2017, meeting, the City Council formed a Finance Ad Hoc Committee consisting of three Councilors. After a one-year trial, the committee would sunset or be renewed.

Mr. Damren said the Finance Committee members believe the Ad Hoc Finance Committee is needed. So far, they have done a revised fund balance policy. They have worked on Resolution

2018-22 Capital Reserve from Sale of City-owned Property and will bring it back to the Council on March 28. There should be a discussion about whether the resolution needs to go to the Policy Committee before a vote is taken.

A motion was made Mr. Pope and seconded by Ms. Kier to continue the Ad Hoc Finance Committee through the balance of this Council term (December 31, 2019).

Mr. Pope said originally he was a hard sell on this, however he finds this committee to be valuable for the community.

Mr. Koloski said he voted against the establishment of this committee. He has since seen the value and will support it.

Mr. O'Hearne said he will endorse/support the committee.

Mr. O'Hearne objected to the word "motion" being on agenda items and would like it removed from future agenda items.

Voice vote: motion carried 6-0.

CITIZEN'S FORUM

Citizen's Forum was scheduled for 7:00 p.m., but the meeting was running ahead of schedule. Mr. Koloski noticed a citizen had arrived before 7:00 p.m. and asked if Council would reopen Citizen's Forum to allow her to speak. There were no Councilor objections.

Rebecca Mackenzie, Ward 2, said Claremont Green Dot Spotlight Week will be March 19-24. Green Dot highlights antiviolence. Green dots signify where someone has intervened against violence. They offer two trainings. One is an hour long and gives an overview. The second is bystander training and it is five hours. It teaches practical skills for intervening directly. It also teaches skills of delegating and how to distract. Many businesses have signed up to be Spotlights. They have passport cards. People get the squares on the passport cards stamped at participating businesses and then the cards are turned in at the Java Cup on March 24. The prizes are \$500, \$100, and \$50. The drawing will be at 12:30 p.m. Turn in your "passport" and get a free cup of coffee. Contact claremontgreendot@gmail.com for information. If businesses want to participate, call 542-8338, ext. 109.

Ms. Mackenzie said she is a member of the Energy Committee and asked anyone who is interested in joining the committee to contact City Hall.

Community-Wide Cleanup Discussion

Mr. McNutt said April is cleanup month. There will be a Tire Take Back Day. There is one roll-off dumpster available. He would like to speak directly with Ward Councilors regarding their plans within their Wards for cleanup activities. He would also like to speak with At-Large

Councilors who know of groups that they would like to work with for cleaning certain areas. A lot of coordination needs to happen with Public Works for the dumpster. This will be to clean up the road sides, not for people to clean up their homes. Hazardous materials thrown in the dumpsters become more expensive to dispose of.

Mr. Pope talked about a cleanup effort a couple of years ago and the Claremont citizen group's participation. He asked about inviting groups (i.e. Conservation Commission, Sullivan County ATV Club, Claremont citizens group and Heart of Claremont) to the March 28th meeting. Mr. McNutt said if everyone can come together, more could get done.

Mr. Pope said he is part of a community engagement group and they have a list of resources. He suggested creating a directory of City groups and what they do. He suggested coordinating with Rebecca Mackenzie, who has a background in community efforts (i.e. solid waste and the Energy Committee).

Mr. Koloski volunteered to supply a case of industrial trash bags to the cleanup effort.

Mr. Damren said the Mayor had sent him some questions:

1. What support can the City employees provide to citizens who take part in a community wide cleanup?
2. What hot spots have City employees noted in their day-to-day operations (i.e. Myrtle Street)?
3. Are there liability issues when citizens participate in cleaning up City-owned property? If so, how would this be resolved? Mr. McNutt said if it were a City-sponsored activity on City property, it would be covered under the City's insurance.

Mr. Pope said when the Claremont citizens group wanted to do the cleanup, they were told they had to sign waivers. Mr. McNutt will check with Primex.

Mr. Damren said to add this to the March 28 agenda.

Mr. Damren said the Steppin' Up to End Violence Walk will be held on Saturday, May 5. He encouraged Councilors to be a part of the walk.

Budget Discussion

Mr. Damren asked Councilors for their budget guidance to the City Manager.

Ms. Kier –

- Don't increase tax rates
- Important to focus on economic development
- Marketing officer would be a benefit for the City and would help to bring people in

Mr. Koloski –

- Focus on economic development

- Don't cut marketing
- Looking forward to hear an update on how the Business Development Coordinator & any grant writing, if any, is working
- Water & sewer increases will hurt a lot of people

Mr. Pope –

- Keep increases to a minimum
- What are the potential losses of state income for the upcoming year
- Would like to see road work (\$250,000 for roadwork equals 34 cents/\$1,000 on the tax rate)
- Would like CIP (Capital Improvements Plan) update on roads
- There have been a lot of cuts in the Economic development/Planning Department
- Need to know how much we have to make up from the loss of state funds. Mr. McNutt will have Mary Walter, Finance Director, put that information in the Finance Report. It's an approximately \$950,000 a year loss.

Mr. O'Hearne –

- Agrees with what he's heard
- Asked if this item would be brought up again when the other Councilors are present. Mr. Damren said he had Mayor Lovett's comments.

Mr. Stone –

- Need to look at water/sewer rates. A lot of people are worried.
- Economic development – strive to get more businesses into Claremont
- Asked for information regarding grants for 2017 and 2018. Mr. McNutt said he can get reports from the departments.
- Road work (potholes)

Mr. Pope asked about ADA (Americans with Disabilities Act) updates for City Hall. He said the curve on the ramp going to the Police Department is too narrow for some wheelchairs. Also, he asked about easier access to get in the front door of the building.

Mr. Koloski said during the Master Plan meetings that there was discussion about having a list of streets and road grades. Mr. McNutt said Scott Sweet, Public Works Director, can give an update.

Mr. Damren read Mayor Lovett's list –

- Maintain or reduce current expenses and increase revenue
- Investments should be made in items that improve operational efficiencies, generate revenue
- Invest in public relations, strategic marketing and grant writing
- Road infrastructure improvements (minimum of \$250,000 is needed)
- Identify life expectancy of roads during budget discussions

- Investment in Southwestern Community Services (transportation). They will be at the March 28th Council meeting.
- City Manager include input from advisory boards when building the budget

Mr. Damren –

- \$275,000-\$375,000 for roads. He feels it would be okay to subsidize that with \$100,000-\$150,000 from fund balance.
- Doesn't want a large tax rate increase.
- In addition to the work to be done on Main Street, do some roadwork in some neighborhoods
- Use reserve funds wherever possible (i.e. Community Center)
- Include listing of full-time and part-time employees per department in the budget book

Mr. Koloski asked if there are funds left in the Council line item at the end of the year, if we could get a system for hearing impaired individuals. He mentioned getting a replacement for the stick that is used to turn on the overhead projector and that some people get a shock when they touch the laptop computer in Council chambers. Mr. McNutt asked, and Council agreed, that Mr. Koloski would work with Mr. McNutt on this request.

Regarding roads, Mr. McNutt said he will meet with Hunter Rieseberg, Newport Town Manager, to discuss bulk purchasing asphalt.

Mr. McNutt said he is tentatively looking at regionalizing emergency dispatch. Upgrading those individual areas is expensive. Newport just got a quote of \$800,000 to update their radios.

Mr. O'Hearne asked if we do bulk purchasing. Mr. Damren said that Ms. Walter works with the schools to bulk purchase heating oil.

Assessment Overview

Mr. McNutt said the City will hire a temporary contracted Assessor after Marlene Jordan, Assessor, leaves. The City is advertising for a Chief Assessor. We are looking for someone with commercial experience.

COMMITTEE REPORTS

Ms. Kier gave a Zoning Board of Adjustment Update –

- Looking for a separate (shorter) board application form for people re-applying for their seats
- Request the Council or Policy Committee review the City Center Zones setbacks and parking standards. The current standards no longer seem to be aligned with current use.
- The Chair would like to follow-up with the Mayor in reference to a resolution about a concern that was voiced previously [no further information was given]

Mr. Pope said the Policy Committee will start meeting in April. They will discuss the lead policy and Resolution 2018-22 Establishment of Non-Capital Reserve for Code Enforcement. He will send Mrs. Russell an email with the meeting information.

FUTURE AGENDA ITEMS AND DIRECTIVES

For the next agenda (March 28), Mr. Damren said to add continuation of the Budget Discussion and Assessment Overview by the City Manager.

Mr. Koloski would like to revisit the truck route that runs through the center of the City. He said he saw a truck drive over the curb around the whole “bullpen.” He is concerned what might happen if there were a problem with an LP tanker. He suggested maybe Pleasant Street could be turned into a one-way street with pull-in parking.

Mr. Koloski would like the Policy Committee to look at a policy that would give guidance to the Council before it accepts donations for such things as the dog park and cemetery lighting to ensure that the projects move forward and the money doesn’t just sit on the City’s books. Mr. Pope said he will need to talk with Ms. Walter regarding the laws on this.

CONSULTATION WITH LEGAL COUNSEL

None

ADJOURNMENT

At 8:29 p.m., a motion was made by Ms. Kier and seconded by Mr. Pope to adjourn.

Voice vote: motion carried 6-0.

Respectfully Submitted,

Dorée M. Russell
Clerk to the Council